

A-level

ENVIRONMENTAL SCIENCE

Paper 1 - Generated practice paper Set 17

Mark scheme

120 marks: Questions 1-10 (95 marks) plus one essay from Question 11 (25 marks).

Marking guidance

- The number in brackets after each marking point is the mark it earns; the note above the points says how many are needed.
- Where a question asks for a fixed number of points (eg *two reasons*), credit only the first points given.
- Alternative correct wording and other relevant, accurate points are credited.
- For levels-of-response questions, first determine the level using the descriptors, then position the mark within the level using the indicative content.
- Calculations: credit correct working (method marks) even if the final answer is wrong; incorrect answers with no working score 0.

Textbook references: every question below cites the printed page numbers in R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018) from which the content is drawn, together with the AQA 7447 specification reference.

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
01.1	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Spoil contains residual sulfide ores (eg iron pyrites, zinc sulfide) (1) • These react with oxygen in the air spaces between the waste particles (oxidation) (1) • Producing metal oxides and oxides of sulfur which dissolve in drainage water to form sulfuric acid (1)	3
01.2	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • The low pH (3.4) directly damages exposed cells / denatures proteins and dissolves calcium-based exoskeletons (1) • Low pH increases the solubility of zinc (0.02 to 6.5 mg dm^{-3}) which is toxic (inhibits enzymes) (1) • Only a few tolerant taxa survive; the sensitive mayfly larvae (indicator of clean water) are eliminated; dissolved oxygen is not the limiting factor here (1)	3
01.3	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Dilution by tributaries / more water (1) • Neutralisation by alkaline rocks (limestone) in the stream bed; zinc precipitates / adsorbs onto sediments as pH rises (1)	2
01.4	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Collect the drainage water and pass it through crushed limestone / add lime to neutralise the acid (1) • Higher pH also reduces the solubility of toxic metals so they precipitate and can be removed (1)	2
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 273-275; AQA spec 3.4.3.2.9-3.4.3.2.10.	

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
02.1	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • A turbofan at the front forces bypass air around the inner cowling / core jet (1) • The bypass air smooths the flow of the turbulent hot exhaust gases, reducing the turbulence that creates noise (1) • The higher the ratio of bypass air to jet exhaust the quieter the engine (Trent 1000 quietest, Olympus noisiest) (1)	3
02.2	<i>Any 2 from the points below - 1 mark each, maximum 2.</i> • Chevron (serrated) nozzles mix bypass air with surrounding air more smoothly (1) • Acoustic liners in the engine cowlings absorb noise (1) • Hush kits fitted to older low-bypass engines (1) • Fairings on undercarriage and wing-flap hinges reduce turbulence; welded rather than riveted panels (1) • Lighter composite aircraft need less thrust (1) • Blended wing with engines on top so the body shields the ground (1)	2
02.3	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Constant (3°) descent avoids periods of high thrust in a stepped descent and keeps aircraft higher for longer (1) • Night flights (especially take-offs, which are noisier) are restricted / banned when people are sleeping and background noise is low (1) • Noisier aircraft pay higher charges / use up more quota points and fines for exceeding limits, so airlines are encouraged to buy quieter aircraft (1) • More time to slow down after landing so wheel brakes can be used instead of noisy reverse thrusters (1)	4
02.4	<i>1 mark.</i> • Engines run at higher power / maximum thrust and the steep climb angle needs full power (although the aircraft climbs quickly out of earshot) (1)	1
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 288-292; AQA spec 3.4.3.2.13.	
03.1	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Spearman's rank correlation coefficient (1) • Mann-Whitney U test (1) • Chi-squared test (1) • t-test (1)	4
03.2	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Chi-squared compares frequencies / counts in categories (1) • Dissolved oxygen is continuously variable measured data, so a t-test or Mann-Whitney U test is needed (1)	2
03.3	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • There is always some remaining uncertainty / a probability that the result was produced by chance (1) • Statistics only give a level of confidence (eg 95%, 99%) that the result is significant (1)	2
03.4	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Bars drawn above and below each mean showing plus and minus one standard deviation (1) • If the bars of two means overlap a lot the difference is probably not significant; if they do not overlap it probably is (1)	2

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 422-423; AQA spec 3.7.2.3.	
04.1	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> - Lowest overnight (about 25 GW at 04:00), rising steeply from 06:00 to about 40 GW by 08:00 (1) - Fairly steady through the day then a peak of about 50 GW at 18:00 (evening) before falling overnight (1)	2
04.2	<i>Up to 4 marks in total; award marks in proportion to the completeness of each point.</i> 24-hour day / night cycle: people asleep overnight; morning rise as heating, lighting, cooking, industry and offices start (up to 2) - Evening peak: lighting, cooking, heating as people return home; short-term 'TV pickup' at programme breaks / mealtimes (up to 2) - Other causes: seasonal (winter heating / lighting, summer air conditioning); weather-related (cold snaps); weekday / weekend differences in industrial use (up to 2)	4
04.3	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> - They generate 24 hours a day because it is uneconomic / slow to turn them off and on, and output changes slowly (1) - Demand falls faster at night than output can be reduced, so the surplus must be stored or is lost as heat from cables (1)	2
04.4	<i>Any 2 from the points below - 1 mark each, maximum 2.</i> - Intermittent renewable resources: wind, solar, tidal (1) - Bulk delivery of transported fuels (oil tankers, coal trains, biofuel harvests) (1) - Breakdowns / maintenance of power stations (1)	2
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 221-222; AQA spec 3.3.4.1.	
05.1	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> - Friction with the prevailing south-westerly winds drags surface water north-eastwards from the tropical Atlantic (1) - Water in the NE Atlantic cools, becomes denser (and more saline as ice forms) and sinks, drawing warm surface water in to replace it; the cold water returns southwards at depth (thermohaline circulation) (1)	2
05.2	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> - Higher temperatures melt land ice on Greenland which flows into the North Atlantic (1) - The fresh water dilutes the seawater, reducing its salinity and density (1) - Less dense water sinks less easily so the flow rate of the current is reduced (1) - Less heat is transported to NW Europe so the UK could become colder (like Moscow / Churchill at the same latitude) even while global temperatures rise (1)	4

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
05.3	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Several interconnected systems act at once over different timescales: jet stream changes may raise temperatures, a slowing Conveyor may lower them, greenhouse gases raise them (1) • Natural fluctuations (solar output, orbit) can hide or exaggerate anthropogenic change; individual events do not show trends (1) • Time delays between cause and effect (oceans take a long time to warm because of volume and heat capacity); incomplete understanding of the processes (1)	3
05.4	<i>1 mark.</i> • Argo floats sink to a set depth for about 10 days, then surface and transmit temperature, salinity and position data; the sequence of positions shows current direction and speed (surface currents also by satellites and buoys) (1)	1
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 96-97; AQA spec 3.2.1.2, 3.2.2.3.	
06.1	<i>Correct answer only.</i> • Oxygen (1)	1
06.2	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • A change to one process causes other processes to alter as a direct result (chains of linked processes / feedback) (1) • There is still a lot that is not understood about how atmospheric processes work (1)	2
06.3	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • The surface warmed in the tropics heats the air above; warm winds (south-westerlies from the Caribbean) carry heat energy to higher latitudes (1) • Winds carry water vapour (evaporated from warm oceans) to areas that would otherwise receive little precipitation (1)	2
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 86-88; AQA spec 3.2.1.1.	
07.1	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Fission: splitting the nuclei of large atoms (U-235, Pu-239) when hit by neutrons (1) • Fusion: joining the nuclei of small atoms (deuterium and tritium - isotopes of hydrogen) to form helium, releasing a neutron and energy - the energy source of stars (1)	2
07.2	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Deuterium (hydrogen-2) extracted from (sea)water (1) • Tritium (hydrogen-3) produced by neutron bombardment of lithium (a lithium blanket around the reactor) (1)	2
07.3	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Very high temperature turns hydrogen into a plasma (electrons stripped away) and gives nuclei enough kinetic energy to overcome the repulsion between positive nuclei and collide (1) • Vacuum so the plasma is not cooled by air (1) • Magnetic field holds the plasma centrally so it does not touch the container walls and cool (1)	3

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
07.4	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> - Fuel (deuterium / lithium) is abundant / effectively unlimited (1) - Much less radioactive waste (no long-lived fission products); no chain reaction / meltdown risk; no weapons material (1) - Not yet achieved sustained net energy output: reactors (JET) use more energy than they release; ITER aims for 500 MW out from 50 MW in; laser fusion also experimental; commercial viability decades away (1)	3
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 195-196; AQA spec 3.3.4.1.	
08.1	<i>Any 3 from the points below - 1 mark each, maximum 3.</i> - Supply rate of energy crops can be controlled and fuels stored so supply matches demand (not intermittent) (1) - Liquid biofuels (alcohol, biodiesel) can replace petrol / diesel in vehicles (1) - Carbon neutral in principle: CO₂ released equals CO₂ absorbed in photosynthesis (1) - Energy density of alcohol / biodiesel nearly as high as fossil fuels; wastes (straw, sewage, landfill gas) are cheap (1)	3
08.2	<i>Any 3 from the points below - 1 mark each, maximum 3.</i> - Large areas of farmland compete with food production or cause clearance of wildlife habitats (eg palm oil) (1) - Intensive farming inputs (fertiliser, pesticide, machinery fuel) may release nearly as much CO₂ as using fossil fuels directly (1) - Low energy density of straw, wood, Miscanthus makes transport uneconomic - must be used locally (1) - Supply from wastes limited to the amount produced (1)	3
08.3	<i>Any 2 from the points below - 1 mark each, maximum 2.</i> - Hydrogen from algae: some algae deprived of sulfur produce hydrogen during photosynthesis (1) - Anaerobic digestion extended to crop wastes and marine algae; small-scale digesters (eg one cow's manure supplying a family's cooking gas) (1) - Biofuels from microorganisms (eg oil-producing microalgae) (1)	2
08.4	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> - Conventional geothermal steam turbines need rocks above 150 °C (recent volcanic activity), too deep to reach economically in the UK (1) - New turbines use fluids such as butane / pentane that boil at low temperatures, so water as cool as 60 °C from deep boreholes / hot dry rock systems can drive them (1)	2
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 212-214; AQA spec 3.3.4.1.	
09.1	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> - The energy used to extract raw materials, manufacture the components and assemble the vehicle (for a typical car about 1.5 years of its fuel use) (1) - Reduced by using recycled materials (eg recycled aluminium needs 1/20 of the energy of new) (1) - Lighter designs using less material; longer vehicle life spreading the embodied energy (1)	3

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
09.2	<i>Any 4 from the points below - 1 mark each, maximum 4.</i> • Use of recyclable materials wherever possible (1) • Easy identification of components and their composition (code stamps) (1) • Easy dismantling and separation of components / materials (1) • Reusable components for new vehicles (1) • Compostable materials for parts that cannot be recycled (1)	4
09.3	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • At low speed a large proportion of the energy just runs the engine rather than moving the car (1) • At high speed energy is wasted overcoming air resistance (which rises with the square of speed); optimum for many cars about 56 mph (1)	2
09.4	<i>1 mark.</i> • Automatic stop / start systems cutting the engine when stationary; smooth driving in higher gears avoiding sudden braking / acceleration (1)	1
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 227-228; AQA spec 3.3.4.2.1.	
10.1	Levels of response Level 3 (7-9 marks): Answer is comprehensive, relevant and logically structured. Shows detailed knowledge and understanding of the relevant scientific ideas and applies them accurately to the context. Evaluation/analysis is well supported by evidence and a clear judgement or conclusion is reached. Level 2 (4-6 marks): Answer is mostly relevant and shows some structure. Knowledge and understanding of relevant ideas is sound but application to the context or evaluation may be incomplete or lack detail. A judgement may be made but is not fully supported. Level 1 (1-3 marks): Answer is basic, with limited structure. Some relevant knowledge is shown but there are omissions or errors. Little application to the context and little or no evaluation. 0 marks: No relevant content. Indicative content (credit other relevant, accurate points) • Context: Lasky's principle - vast quantities exist at low grade; reserves vs resource; COOG affected by price, technology, energy costs • Improved exploration: higher resolution multispectral satellite sensors, IR spectroscopy, gravimetry, magnetometry, seismic, resistivity, portable field analysis, targeted trial drilling • Mechanisation allowing deeper underground mines and larger open-cast mines • Low-energy extraction of low-grade ores: bioleaching with acidophilic bacteria and fungi, phytomining, iron displacement, bacterial adsorption of rare earths, polymer adsorption from seawater • Previously inaccessible deposits: polymetallic nodules, deep sea sediments, Antarctica (currently protected) - environmental and legal issues • Extending use: recycling (advantages, difficulties), Cradle to Cradle design, product lifetime extension, substitution of scarce materials, circular economy • Evaluation: environmental impacts vs benefits; energy costs; economics; which strategies are most sustainable; conclusion	9
	Model answer - Level 3 (8 marks)	

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
	Lasky's principle means that as grade falls, the quantity of metal available rises enormously, so depletion of high-grade deposits does not mean running out - it means the cut-off ore grade must fall, which depends on price, technology and energy costs. Better exploration finds what remains: high-resolution multispectral and infrared satellite sensors, gravimetry, magnetometry, seismic and resistivity surveys and portable field analysers narrow the search so expensive trial drilling is targeted. Mechanisation allows deeper underground mines and larger open-cast pits, and previously inaccessible deposits - polymetallic nodules and deep-sea sediments, and Antarctica if its protection were ever lifted - become possible, with serious environmental and legal problems.	
	The most sustainable route to low-grade ores is low-energy extraction: bioleaching with acidophilic bacteria and fungi, phytomining, iron displacement of copper, bacterial adsorption of rare earths and polymer adsorption from seawater all avoid the energy of crushing and smelting vast tonnages. Equally important is extending the use of metal already mined: recycling, Cradle-to-Cradle design so products can be disassembled, longer product lifetimes and substitution of scarce metals - the circular economy approach.	
	Each strategy has costs: deep-sea mining and Antarctica risk unique habitats, deeper mines need more energy, recycling is limited by dispersal and mixed alloys. The strategies that mimic natural low-temperature processes and keep metals in use are the most sustainable, and exploration and new mining should be the last resort rather than the first.	
	Weaker answer - Level 1 (3 marks)	
	When high grade ores run out we can mine lower grade ores instead, but this uses more energy. Better technology like satellites can find new deposits. We could mine the deep sea or Antarctica. Bacteria can be used to extract metals from low grade ore. Recycling metals means we do not need to mine as much. These strategies will help secure supplies of metals in the future.	
	What makes the difference	
	• Level 1 names most strategy types but Level 3 explains each (what the surveys measure, why low-temperature extraction matters, what Lasky's principle implies).	
	• Level 3 weighs environmental and energy costs and ranks the strategies; Level 1 offers no evaluation.	
	• Framing the answer with the concept of cut-off ore grade shows understanding rather than recall.	
10.2	<i>1 mark.</i> • All of the material that exists in the lithosphere, including that which will never be technologically or economically exploitable (1)	1
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 130-147; AQA spec 3.2.3.	

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
11.1	Discuss the extent to which the study of ozone depletion illustrates how scientific investigation can lead to the successful solution of an environmental problem. Levels of response Level 5 (21-25 marks): Comprehensive and detailed knowledge and understanding drawn from across the specification, applied accurately to the question. Argument is coherent, well-structured and supported by a wide range of relevant, well-chosen examples and quantitative detail where appropriate. Interconnections between topics are made explicitly and a clear, justified conclusion is reached. Level 4 (16-20 marks): Detailed knowledge and understanding with good application to the question. Argument is logically organised with relevant examples; some links between different areas of the specification are made. Conclusions are drawn but may be less fully justified. Level 3 (11-15 marks): Sound knowledge and understanding, mostly applied to the question. Some structure and relevant examples, but coverage may be uneven or descriptive rather than analytical. Limited linking of topics. Level 2 (6-10 marks): Basic knowledge and understanding with partial relevance. Answer is largely descriptive with few examples and limited structure; some errors or omissions. Level 1 (1-5 marks): Limited, fragmented knowledge with little relevance to the question. Little structure; examples absent or inappropriate. 0 marks: No relevant content. Indicative content (students are not expected to cover all of these; credit other relevant material) • Stages of investigation: identifying the issue (Halley Station UV data, Dobson unit measurements), hypothesis formation (Rowland-Molina 1974: persistence, UV dissociation, chlorine reactions), data collection (ground, satellite, balloon and aircraft air sampling detecting ClO), analysis of spatial, temporal and altitude variability, proposal of solutions, enactment • Why Antarctica: low stratospheric temperatures, ice crystals, stratospheric clouds, polar vortex, spring sunlight • Effects of UVB: skin cancer, cataracts, DNA damage, plant and marine damage - motivating action • Solutions: Vienna Convention, Montreal Protocol - phase-out and bans, alternative processes (pump sprays), alternative materials (HCFCs, HFCs, hydrocarbons, HFAs), collection and incineration of CFCs, fund for developing countries • Evaluation of success: ozone hole area / depth stabilising, CFC levels falling; limitations - persistence, remaining ODSs, HFCs as greenhouse gases, decades to full recovery • Comparison with other atmospheric problems (climate change, acid rain) - why ozone was easier; role of peer review, international cooperation, availability of substitutes • Conclusion on the extent to which it is a model for other issues Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 108-113; AQA spec 3.2.1.3.	25

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
11.2	Explain how feedback mechanisms and tipping points influence the rate of global climate change and discuss the implications for the strategies needed to control it. Levels of response Level 5 (21-25 marks): Comprehensive and detailed knowledge and understanding drawn from across the specification, applied accurately to the question. Argument is coherent, well-structured and supported by a wide range of relevant, well-chosen examples and quantitative detail where appropriate. Interconnections between topics are made explicitly and a clear, justified conclusion is reached. Level 4 (16-20 marks): Detailed knowledge and understanding with good application to the question. Argument is logically organised with relevant examples; some links between different areas of the specification are made. Conclusions are drawn but may be less fully justified. Level 3 (11-15 marks): Sound knowledge and understanding, mostly applied to the question. Some structure and relevant examples, but coverage may be uneven or descriptive rather than analytical. Limited linking of topics. Level 2 (6-10 marks): Basic knowledge and understanding with partial relevance. Answer is largely descriptive with few examples and limited structure; some errors or omissions. Level 1 (1-5 marks): Limited, fragmented knowledge with little relevance to the question. Little structure; examples absent or inappropriate. 0 marks: No relevant content. Indicative content (students are not expected to cover all of these; credit other relevant material) • Negative feedback: increased low-level cloud (albedo), increased photosynthesis and sequestration; hydrological cycle evaporation-precipitation • Positive feedback: melting permafrost (methane), reduced albedo of snow / ice / sea ice, methane hydrate release, ocean acidification and coral loss, forest and peat fires, soil decomposition, water vapour, cirrus clouds • Tipping points: self-sustaining processes; why control must precede them; examples • Implications: urgency and precautionary principle; need for deep cuts in greenhouse gases (energy, transport, buildings, agriculture, forestry, CCS) rather than only adaptation; geoengineering risks • Difficulty of prediction because feedbacks interact at different scales; models; international agreements and per capita footprints • Judgement on whether current strategies are adequate Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 103-107, 371-372; AQA spec 3.2.1.2, 3.6.1.	25